My Thoughts on Responsible AI Usage

As a second-year college student, I've noticed that AI has become an essential part of our daily lives and coursework. It's not just a tool for tech majors anymore; everyone is using it. But like we often hear in our labs, we have to use AI carefully. It shouldn't be a shortcut to cheat or replace our actual work, but rather a tool to enhance our abilities. At the end of the day, we are entirely responsible for whatever our AI generates.

Here is my take on using AI responsibly, based on my own experiences and our course rules.

Have I used AI before?

Absolutely! I use AI pretty frequently, especially tools like ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot, and Gemini. Coming into my sophomore year, the coursework (especially coding and algorithms) got a lot harder. I've used AI mainly as a highly available tutor.

For example, In the marioGame project, I experimented with using AI agents and code assistants (like GitHub Copilot and Google Anitigravity) as virtual co-developers. When building mechanics like variable jump heights, enemy pathing, and bounding-box collision handling, I asked the model to propose standard approaches and physics algorithms. I also use it to help debug my code when I hit a wall, or to suggest ways to make my code run a bit faster. However, I've learned the hard way that you can't just trust it blindly—sometimes it generates code that looks perfect but completely fails the edge test cases.

My Experience and Tips for Using AI

Through trial and error, and by following our faculty's rules, I've picked up a few tips on how to use AI without crossing the line into academic dishonesty:

- **Treat AI like a guide, not a replacement:** Use it to look up information, get formatting suggestions, or check your grammar. But never use it to generate your entire report or auto-generate solutions and analysis. You still need to do the heavy lifting.
- **No blind copying:** This is a big one. Never just copy and paste AI-generated code or text without understanding it. If a professor asks you to explain your code during an oral exam and you can't, you're in huge trouble. Always rephrase things in your own words.
- **Always verify your facts:** AI hallucinates. It's not an official academic source. Always cross-verify the information it gives you with your textbook or lecture slides to ensure academic integrity.
- **Follow the "AI Usage Guidelines.pdf":** Our faculty takes this very seriously. According to the "AI Usage Guidelines.pdf", we have to be completely transparent. This means if you use AI to help outline a report or debug a function, you *must* declare it in the Appendix. You have to include the tool name, the exact prompt you used, what the AI generated, and how you independently verified or edited it.
- **Keep your receipts:** Save your chat history and take screenshots! If there's ever a question about how much of the work is yours, having a clear log of your prompts and the AI's responses will save you. The penalties for hiding your AI use are super harsh (getting a zero for the whole course on the second strike!).

Using AI is an awesome way to learn faster, but only if we use it transparently and actually take the time to understand the output.